

SWEET POTATOES *Ipomoea batatas*

Sweet potatoes are not related to potatoes at all but are actually members of the bindweed family. Like potatoes, though, their orange or white flesh is delicious roasted, baked, or mashed. They originate from tropical or subtropical climates so will only produce a good crop during a very warm summer, or if grown in a greenhouse. Raise your own seeds under cover and then plant out, or, alternatively, buy rooted cuttings called “slips.”

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW/PLANT				
HARVEST				

SOWING & PLANTING

Sweet potatoes need a warm, sheltered site, with sandy, highly fertile soil and a pH range of 5.5–6.5. Sow indoors in trays or pots at a depth of 1 in (2.5 cm) in early to mid-spring. Harden off and transplant once the young plants reach a height of about 4–6 in (10–15 cm). If growing from slips, plant out in late spring.

Create a 12 in (30 cm) high ridge in the soil and plant seedlings or slips at least 10–12 in (25–30 cm) apart; plant slips 2–3 in (5–8 cm) deep. Bear in mind that sweet potatoes grow very large and will need plenty of space—at least 30 in (75 cm) between rows. Consider trimming foliage or training it up wire supports to keep your plot looking neat.



Trim the foliage to keep it under control.

CROP CARE

Sweet potatoes require a lot of water, especially during their early growth period. Consider sinking the tops of cut-off plastic bottles upside down into the soil around your crops, since pouring water into these will ensure that it reaches right down to the roots. Feed your sweet potatoes with a balanced fertilizer every two to three weeks.